On the issue of broadening of conceptions of religion upon Christianity's encounter with indigenous societies, Torres' interpretation of Columbus' encounter with the native peoples of Americas differed from Wynter's. He was of the view that since Christianity recognised only three categories—Christians, infidels and idolators—Columbus initially struggled to place the natives of the Americas in any of the three, and, therefore, assumed that they were not people from a 'wrong' or 'false' religion, but were simply without religion. The absence of religion was perceived as absence of a soul in Christian thought, with the soul being a condition precedent for a human to establish a connection with the divine. This divide between those with a soul and without, according to Torres, led to race consciousness in the European coloniser, because the coloniser saw the coloured native people as 'non-souls'. This converted religion into an anthropological category because it had become a marker of race.

That the European Christian coloniser was White and the native peoples were 'Black' (or of colour) was not lost on the former. Therefore, the White Christian became the one with a soul, and therefore fully human, while the Black native was without a soul, and therefore not fully human, or simply non-human. Owing to this crucible of religion, race and colour, the soulless non-Christian Black natives were subjected to religion-induced dehumanisation, which justified and facilitated their treatment as slaves, or at the very least, as those upon whom the light of Christianity, Europeanness and civilisation had to be shone.

Entire continents and societies were associated with soullessness, requiring either enslavement or conversion, since adopting Christianity was believed to infuse a soul into the dark soulless native. In other words, in the eyes of the Christian European coloniser, he was not merely 'saving' the soul of a non-Christian infidel or idolator but was breathing soul into a Satan-worshipping subhuman, an animal, through his Christianising and civilising European touch. If this healing touch was resisted, the subhuman had to be put down ruthlessly like a beast. What is important to note is that whether approached from the perspective of Wynter, where natives were seen as idolators by Columbus, or from the point of view of Torres, that Columbus considered them soulless, both views emanated from Christian OET as it existed then and shared a common purpose—native non-Christian communities had to convert or die.